Nevertheless, India's expenditure on health as a per cent of GDP is lower than in many other emerging and developed countries and the share of the public sector still lower.

Poverty has declined in the country, though precisely how poverty is measured is currently being examined. Based on the methodology suggested by the Tendulkar Committee, the percentage of people living below the poverty line in the country declined from 37.2 per cent in 2004-05 to 29.8 per cent in 2009-10. Even in absolute terms, the number of poor people declined by 52.4 million during this period. Of this, 48.1 million are rural poor and 4.3 million urban poor. Thus poverty has declined on an average by 1.5 percentage points per year between 2004-05 and 2009-10. The annual average rate of decline during the period 2004-05 to 2009-10 is twice the rate of decline during the period 1993-94 to 2004-05.

In the last few years public expenditure on **social programmes** increased dramatically. In the Eleventh Plan period nearly Rs. 7 lakh crore has been spent on the 15 major flagship programmes. A number of legislative steps have also been taken to secure the rights of people, like –

i. the Right to Information Act, the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA);
ii. the Forest Rights Act; and
iii. the Right to Education (RTE).

However, there are also pressing governance issues like programme leakages and funds not reaching the targeted beneficiaries that need to be addressed. Direct benefit transfer (DBT) with the help of the Unique Identification (UID) number can help plug some of these leakages.

Sustainable Development and Climate Change

Though multilateral efforts on sustainable development and climate change have led to several positive outcomes, there are still **areas of concern** where further work is needed to safeguard the interests of developing countries. The key question to be addressed is equity in the evolving arrangements. It has to be ensured that domestic goals continue to be nationally determined even as we contribute to the global efforts according to the principle of **CBDR** (Common but Differentiated Responsibilities).